ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Exam Preparation and Revision: A Four-Week Plan That Holds Up

Plan, practise and manage exam-day pressure without last-minute panic

STUDY SKILLS

Study Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

This pack gives you a four-week revision architecture, a way to prioritise courses by risk and weight, and exam-hall technique for multiple-choice, theory and calculation papers. It also covers the practical side: materials, timing and the night before.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Build a four-week revision plan prioritised by course risk.
- Use spaced testing instead of rereading slides.
- Apply paper-specific exam technique for objective, theory and calculation questions.
- Manage exam anxiety and the 24 hours before a paper.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Prioritise before you plan

Not every course deserves equal time. Rank them by consequence and current weakness.

- List every course with its credit unit and exam date.
- Rate your current confidence from one to five with evidence, not feeling.
- Compute a simple priority score: credit units times the gap between confidence and five.
- Give the highest scores more blocks, but never abandon a course entirely.
- Protect the courses with early exam dates from being crowded out.
- Put the plan on paper where you can see it daily.

The four-week architecture

Spread the work so the final week is consolidation, not first-time learning.

1. Week four before: skim all syllabi, gather materials, write topic checklists.
2. Week three: cover the weakest high-priority topics, one past question per course.
3. Week two: active recall across all courses, timed sections, fix repeated errors.
4. Week one: full past papers under exam conditions, then targeted repair only.
5. Each day: two or three courses maximum, alternating heavy and lighter subjects.
6. Last 48 hours: review summaries, formula sheets and error logs. No new topics.

> **Test, do not reread**
> Rereading creates familiarity. Closing the book and writing from memory creates the retrieval skill the exam actually requires.

In the hall

Exam technique is worth marks independent of knowledge.

- Read all instructions and check the number of questions and sections.
- Budget time per question and keep a few minutes for review.
- Answer the easiest questions first to secure marks and settle nerves.
- For objective questions, answer every item unless there is a penalty for guessing.
- For theory, define terms, structure with paragraphs and use examples.
- For calculations, show method, units and a final statement. Box your answer.

> **If you blank**
> Write the question in your own words, list what you know about the topic and start with the definition. Motion usually returns recall.

Revision is retrieval under exam conditions

Most students revise by reading notes and highlighting, which produces a feeling of familiarity that collapses in the exam hall. The exam does not ask you to recognise your notes; it asks you to produce an answer from memory within a time limit. So revision must practise that exact activity.

Past questions are the best available evidence of what the examiner values. Work them closed-book, under time, then mark your own answer against the course outline and the marks available. The gap between what you wrote and what was required is your revision list.

Distribute practice across the weeks before the exam. Five sessions of one hour across five days beats one five-hour session, because each session begins with forgetting that must be overcome - and that effort is what consolidates memory.

The revision plan

Start from the syllabus, not from the notes. For each topic, rate your confidence honestly: can explain, can apply, can analyse, cannot yet. Sort the topics into those three groups and allocate time by weakness, not by comfort. Students revise what they already know because it feels productive.

Build a one-page summary per topic - not a rewrite of the notes, but the skeleton: definitions, key claims, one worked example, one common error. If you cannot produce the page from memory, you do not yet know the topic.

Practise the format. If the exam has multiple choice, practise speed and elimination; if it has essays, practise planning in five minutes and writing in thirty-five; if it has calculations, practise under time with the formula sheet you will actually be given.

> **The blank page test**
> Take a blank sheet, write the topic heading, and reproduce everything you know in five minutes. Then check. That single exercise predicts exam performance better than any amount of highlighting.

The week before and the day itself

In the final week, reduce new material to zero and increase retrieval. Sleep is part of revision: memory consolidation happens during sleep, and a night of cramming costs more than it gains.

Prepare logistics in advance - venue, time, identification, materials, transport - so that the morning is not a source of stress. Arrive early. Read the whole paper before starting and allocate minutes per question according to marks.

In the hall, answer the question asked. Underline the command word: define, explain, compare, discuss, evaluate, calculate. Each requires a different structure, and a brilliant answer to the wrong command scores poorly.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Turning a past paper into a revision plan

You have four past papers and three weeks.

1. List every question by topic across the four papers.
2. Identify the topics that recur - these are core.
3. Sit one paper closed-book under time to establish a baseline.
4. Mark it against the outline and list what was missing.
5. Allocate the next two weeks to the recurring topics you performed worst on.
6. Sit the remaining papers in the final week under exam conditions.

> **What to carry forward**
> Recurrence identifies the core; your own marked answers identify the gaps.

2. Planning an essay answer in five minutes

The question is: "Discuss the view that technology has improved education in Nigeria."

1. Underline the command: discuss means present both sides and reach a position.
2. Write a one-sentence position.
3. List three arguments for and two against, with one example each.
4. Choose an order that builds rather than alternates.
5. Allocate minutes per section according to marks.
6. Write, leaving two minutes to check that you answered the question.

> **What to carry forward**
> Position, arguments, order, timing. Planning costs five minutes and saves fifteen.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Why is distributed practice more effective than massed practice?

10 marks

1. Each session begins with partial forgetting, requiring effortful retrieval.
2. Effortful retrieval consolidates memory.
3. Sleep between sessions supports consolidation.
4. Massed practice produces familiarity without durability.

Q2. Explain how command words change the structure of an answer.

15 marks

1. Define: state meaning precisely, with an example.
2. Explain: give reasons and mechanisms.
3. Compare: use criteria and cover both sides within each.
4. Discuss: present positions and reach a judgement.
5. Evaluate: assess against criteria and state a conclusion.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Distributed practice. Spacing study sessions over days rather than massing them.

Retrieval practice. Recalling material from memory to strengthen it.

Command word. The verb in a question that specifies the required structure.

Mark scheme. The criteria used to allocate marks to an answer.

Baseline. A first timed attempt used to measure current performance.

Consolidation. The stabilising of memory, supported by sleep.

Formative self-assessment. Marking your own work to identify gaps.

Time allocation. Dividing exam minutes according to the marks available.

Topic skeleton. A one-page summary of a topic's core structure.

Exam conditions. Closed-book, timed practice that mirrors the real assessment.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Audit

Baseline.

- Sit one past paper closed-book and timed.
- Mark it against the outline.
- List the three weakest topics.

Week 2 - Repair

Weak topics.

- Write one-page skeletons from memory.
- Do five retrieval sessions across the week.
- Re-test the weakest topic.

Week 3 - Conditions

Timing.

- Sit two papers under exam conditions.
- Practise planning in five minutes.
- Check command-word structures.

Week 4 - Taper

Consolidation.

- Reduce new material.
- Review skeletons only.
- Protect sleep and logistics.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- A revision guide covering retrieval practice and spacing.
- Past papers and mark schemes for your courses.
- Your faculty examination regulations.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why is a confidence rating with evidence better than a feeling?

Answer: Evidence such as past-question scores prevents overconfidence and targets study where marks are actually at risk.

2. What should the last 48 hours before an exam contain?

Answer: Review of summaries, formula sheets and an error log. No new topics and no all-night cramming.

3. How should you use a past paper?

Answer: First as a timed diagnostic under exam conditions, then as a source of an error log that drives targeted repair.

4. Give two exam-hall strategies for theory papers.

Answer: Plan a brief outline before writing, and define key terms early with a concrete example.

5. Why is it risky to study only one course for days?

Answer: Other courses decay through disuse, and the schedule may not leave time to recover them.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] List every course with credit units and exam dates.
- [ ] Rate your confidence with evidence from a past question.
- [ ] Build the four-week plan on paper.
- [ ] Complete one timed past paper per course.
- [ ] Start an error log and update it after each practice.
- [ ] Prepare a one-page formula and definition sheet per course.
- [ ] Rehearse exam-day logistics: venue, time, materials and transport.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

ZikShare Academic Vault | Study Skills | 100L | 2026 Fresher Edition

YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: